American radar screen to becoming a ‘strategic partner’ is remarkable. The wheel seems to have taken a full turn.

During my visit to the US in November 2006, we were very warmly received and taken around. During the discussions and meetings at the Pentagon, I had the privilege of meeting Defence Secretary Donald Rumsfeld. There was a detailed interaction with General Peter J. Schoomaker, their chief of staff of the army, and other officers. We visited the US military academy at West Point; the training and doctrine command at Fort Monroe; and Forts Benning in Georgia, Lewis in Seattle, and Irwin near Los Angeles. At Fort Irwin we were taken to the national training centre and were shown a training facility depicting an Arab village called ‘Medina Jabal’ in the desert. All troops going into deployment in Iraq were trained at this institution.

After the disintegration of the Soviet Union, there was a period of uncertainty and political upheaval in that region for a few years. Russia has been a time-tested friend of our country. India and Russia are in the process of enhancing their cooperation in various fields such as space research, defence, science and technology, trade and energy. The landmark visit of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh to Russia in December 2009 gave a further boost to our existing close ties. During this visit, ‘six important agreements were signed apart from the adoption of a joint declaration on “further deepening the strategic partnership”, thus reflecting the shared vision of the two countries on many global issues.’[1]

We have a vibrant relationship as far as defence cooperation is concerned, with a regular exchange of visits, joint training exercises, courses of instruction, transfers of weapon systems and equipment and transfer of technology. Certain joint projects have been initiated for the development of missiles and futuristic fifth-generation aircraft. The Brahmos supersonic cruise missile is an outstanding example of such collaboration. While we improve our relations with other countries, we must consolidate and further strengthen our ties with the Russian Federation.